Why do organizations find themselves in situations with more objectives than instruments? Jan Tinbergen's assignment principle has been around since the 1960s; surely, everyone knows it by now.

Public choice theory predicts that public organizations will *favour* multiple objectives as this gives reduced accountability. Clarity of purpose is efficient for the principal and not the agent. It is our job, as policy thinkers, to hold the metaphoric feet of every agency to the fire, and hold it accountable for a narrow set of goals associated with a narrow set of powers. This requires drafting modern laws that clearly articulate objectives and establish commensurate accountability mechanisms.

Formal process helps

In the informal ways of policymaking, the risk of failing to pose the right question is greater. In the conventional informal ways, many things are talked about orally, a vague picture is assembled of a problem, and actions are proposed, yielding a three-page note.

The formal discipline of policymaking generates improvements by forcing a due process. We are forced to write down: What is the problem that we are trying to solve? Are we able to demonstrate that there is a market failure? Do we have an instrument through which the identified problem can be addressed? Has this instrument already been used up to pursue other objectives?

Formal documentation is required, before every move in public policy, which conducts such analysis. Without such formal statements, we run the risk of degenerating into shifting goalposts: An objective is stated, it fails to work out, the authorities then claim that the true objective was a different one.